

THE AGE

MELBOURNE LIVING

edited by STEPHEN DOWNES and PETER WEINIGER (Epicure)

SPIRITING ACROSS THE BAY

IT IS one of those grey gleaming days at Port Melbourne. Thirty people decide it will be a day out of the ordinary, an escapade.

A Greek taxi driver drops me at Station Pier, a place with different resonances for different people. It is where he started his life in Australia. He remembers the great worn boat, the crowds of the '50s, the shrillness of welcome. For me it is a hundred winter Sundays, chips and doughnuts from old grey vans. It is my father diving off the pier in the '30s, coming up with a clutch of dead hair that he thought was seaweed, and a body trailing at the end of it.

Many Melbourne people have strong associations with the bay, but most of us are landlocked. We think of Sydney and Perth as water cities. Several years back, however, a group of men got together to challenge this. They were ex-bay pilots and keen seagoers, who viewed Melbourne differently.

To them it is a port city, surrounded by charming coastal villages to which it was originally linked by ferries. With the advent of the car these services vanished and mainly the rich went out on the water.

They formed a company and searched for a boat. It is their intention to lure the rest of us back to the bay.

The Spirit of Victoria, built in Hobart and finished in mid-July, is a lightweight, high-speed catamaran. It is the first of its kind in Victoria, a wave-piercing boat that is fast but smooth, that cuts through the top of waves rather than going up and over them. It is three levels high, has a 240-horsepower motor and carries 217 people. Each Friday, Saturday and Sunday it makes round trips from Station Pier to Mornington, to Queenscliff, Portarlington and Sorrento. You can stay aboard for 3½ hours, or break for a long leisurely lunch, a stroll, a game of golf. There are private night charters, with discos and catering. It is something new, yet something old. The owners are restoring a tradition that once belonged to Melbourne.

At 10.15 the sun is shining thinly, and little waves are flicking round the boat. The Spirit of Victoria looks small and flatish, dwarfed for the moment by the crude container ship behind it and the Abel-Tasman to the left. People are boarding quietly, singles in duffel coats, a neat trio, an old man hobbling on a stick. They walk beside fishermen through wide gauges straddled by the old Pier House.

Jodie Jones, once a secretary, and William Wallace, ex-fisherman from New Zealand's Bay of Islands, are circulating easily. They are bright young people with warm, quick faces. They wear windbreakers blazoning "I've caught The Spirit". With Matthew Oli, a handsome Fijian who married a Melbourne woman, they have taken courses in sea safety, fire-fighting and first aid. Harbor Trust officials prod and squeeze the life jackets, spread for inspection one to a seat. Industrial Melbourne throbs at our backs until the boat starts with a quick surge of power.

The journey is immediately exciting. I sit outside in the open, with that wonderful sea-in-the-hair feeling. Young people are coming out in couples, their coats whipping wildly, while the older ones shelter within. West Gate Bridge, the oil dumps, the industrial cranes all recede briskly in a white wash of water. The photographer, mindful of his duties, tries to take a Preston couple huddling at the rails. It is the girl's first time on the water. She thinks it perfectly feasible that she might die.

By LESLEYANNE HAWTHORNE

"Talk to each other! Just talk to each other naturally!" he yells, trying to set up a shot.

"We can't! We're not meant to be here!" squeals the girl, ducking her head. They are married to other people.

ABOVE the sound of the engine and the sea, the calm, clear voice of Captain Geoff Parish provides a commentary. The bay is big — 200 square kilometres, with an entrance three kilometres wide. There are extensive sand banks, mud islands of 400 acres, tidal lagoons and colonies of bird life.

The history is rich, and it has shaped Melbourne. Port Phillip was discovered by Europeans in February 1802, and Queenscliff became the original port. Victoria's first governor, Charles La Trobe, built a seaside cottage there 40 years later. In spite of the difficulties of office and accessibility he must have loved it. He went there most weekends, hitching a passing ship to Geelong, then riding the remaining 30 kilometres. He named the new township in honor of the Queen, and a wooden lighthouse was built in 1842. Attacks were expected from everywhere — the Russians, the French, the Americans too. You can chase this up in the Queenscliff Historical Rooms. There are even rumors of buried treasure!

I know none of this, or anything else in the captain's speech. It is a fine, clear ride as we listen. The boat charges dramatically from the port right across the bay. White spray flies into the air, as the Preston girl plans strategies in case of sinking. Others are walking round the deck in mild sunshine, smiling. A middle-aged, balding man comes outside, waves cheerily at the shore, and views Melbourne's demise with satisfaction.

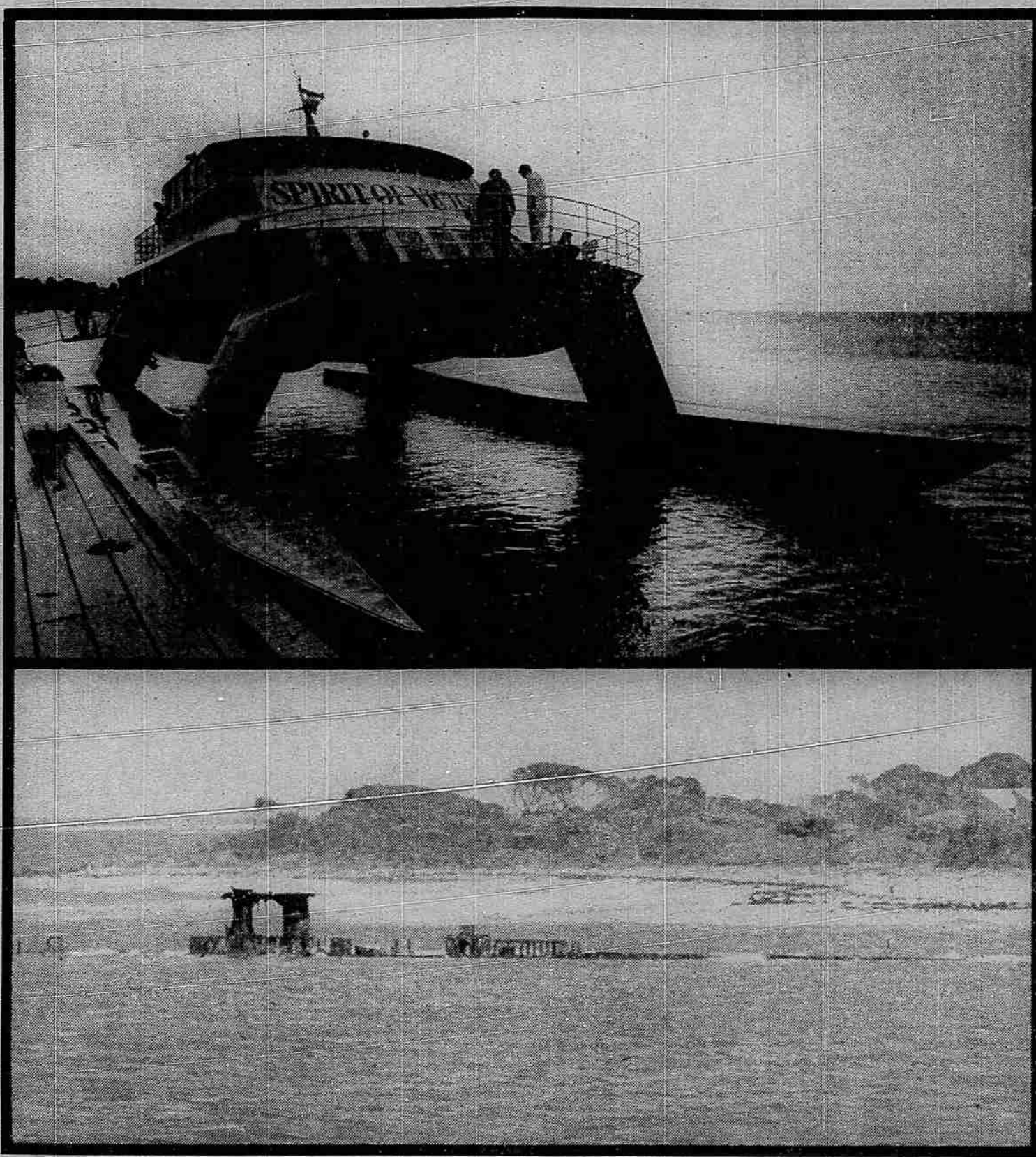
We are for the moment bound together with a splendid sense of being adventurers, of abandoning routine, of leaving the towers of the city reduced to so many twigs in the distance.

The boat lurches, and I go flying as the waving man comes across to me, laughing. "I'm used to that!" he says smugly, balancing on the balls of his feet. "I'm a tram conductor, you see, and I've got my balancing shoes on. I know how to stay upright — but mind, this is a bit different from a tram."

He admits to living at Thomastown, but like the escapade couple is nervous about saying his name. "I don't usually give my name to the papers," he says, "because I'm a tram conductor and that's one of the things we don't do." Nonetheless I soon know he is Geoff Dunlop, ex-scout master from King Island, ex-farmer from Shepparton. I ask why he came on the boat.

"Well, it's a great way to go round the bay!" he says, gesturing widely and beaming as we follow a course down the Bellarine Peninsula. "I've got four days off from work in a row, and it's one of those things that we should enjoy a lot more of. You're cutting off miles from driving to get places! Taken hour by hour it's value for money. People need to consider the pleasure they can get from travelling just on the water! I've been on a ferry or two in Sydney, and to tell you truly this is a much more pleasurable vehicle. It's spacious, and it's immaculately clean. Those hydrofoils get a little grubby as the years go by."

"I hope they build a lot more of these," he continues, expanding in his role as informant, "because they can lead to a lot of friends. You used to make friendships that stood you in good stead, 10 or 15 years, on the old ferries! People



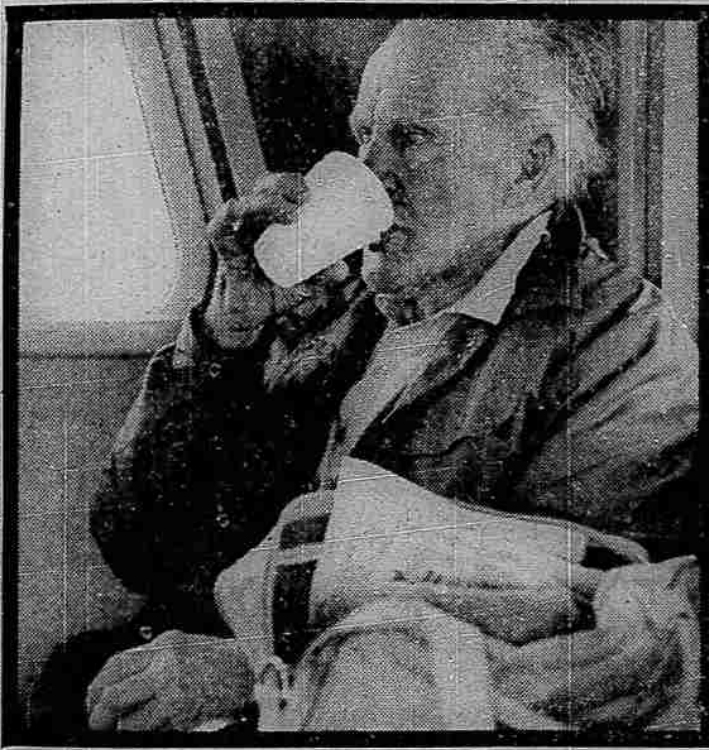
TOP: The Spirit at Sorrento. ABOVE: Swan Island, near Queenscliff.

used to get along on one particular day of the year, they'd travel to Geelong or Mornington to picnic races when road transport wasn't so prevalent. People could expect each other, someone would bring along a piano accordion, the old squeezebox, and you'd have a bit of a sing-along."

WE ARE out in midwater, where the photographer looks more and more intrepid, bracing himself against the rails of the boat, sticking his head out in a blast of Antarctic wind for a better angle. I join another couple, standing simply in parkas, their faces thrilled. Queenscliff is coming into focus in appealing detail. Instead of being one grey-green blob we see the varied shading of trees, the white sand, the little beach houses that were the envy of my childhood.

Like half the others on the boat these are working-class people.

Eric Richards, an inhabitant of Queenscliff for most of his life and a teller of its tales in a torrent of vivid images.



Pictures: RODGER CUMMINS

Eddie Von Tilborg, born in Holland, is unemployed. His gentle wife Robyn is a sorter with the Egg Board. You might imagine that they would find the cost (see end of story) prohibitive. But they have wanted to make this trip since they first saw it advertised.

When Robyn's holidays came they mapped out what they could do carefully. They've taken excursions here and there, but kept this day to be the best of it.

We are passing Swan Island, says the captain, giving a fresh spile of information. It is believed to be an ASIO headquarters where troops are trained. People on the boat get up and peer curiously at the clutter of buildings, with a golf course green behind it. We are coming in to land, skirting a wrecked breakwater submarine, sighting a long low chain of hills. Inside the cabin the neat trio are having an elegant lunch, from a basket. A couple eat across the table from a man with his hands

crossed delicately on his belly. He has carefully combed hair, a thick gold necklace, and a sporty leather jacket.

"Ah, that's a sight you don't often see!" says the tram conductor, materialising suddenly beside me. It does look good on shore — the tower of the fine old Queenscliff Hotel rearing above the trees, the glimpse of an older holiday world shaping behind it.

Abruptly there is an announcement. The captain has just been warned that we can't dock at Queenscliff, for a squall is coming across the water. Jodie Jones hastens to the little crippled man, hunched in a corner, who had wanted to get off.

Eric Richards is 53 but looks 70. He's lived in Queenscliff most of his life, and is a stream-of-consciousness torrent of local history.

He took the boat up to Melbourne on Sunday "to try it out". Then he put up at the Salvation Army hostel because it was cheap. "But oh, the drunks! The smell! You should've seen 'em! One fella across the road from me was jumping all over the place!"

"I've been an invalid most of my life," he says matter-of-factly as I join him. "You just got to go steady. Got bone poisoning when I was 10. Oh, the pain that shot up me! Ever seen a rabbit slit open?" I shake my head dumbly. "Well, that was what me leg was like, all poison. They opened it up, and the knee just popped out! So they took the leg. Take a look at this, dear."

He hitchies up his old trousers, revealing a bright plastic calf, thigh and knee. "Now that happened when we was up in the farmland. My father always said it would never've happened if we stayed near the sea!"

The Spirit is streaming through grey-green waves closer to Sorrento. "The paddle boats were lovely, darling," he tells me chattily. "You should've seen them, they were fitted out. Beautiful! Ozone first, then Weeroona, and then the Hygeia. It all come about from the Baillieu family — you know, them rich people with the shop in Bourke Street. They had the Ozone Hotel at Queenscliff. Beautiful it is for a Friday dinner, all you can eat, and the views! They named the boat for the hotel. Of course there were eight hotels here in the wartime, the first war. It was a bigger place then than it is now, because you see it's military, and that's why a lot don't come here."

"Lord Kitchener, the military man, come down here in the 1914 war. He got a thousand men to go, and they took them in the early hours of the morning in the troopship Queen Mary, the biggest ship afloat. Took them to war all in darkness, and half of them never come back. Lord Kitchener was after recruits, you see! My father, the fisherman, told him straight he

wasn't going to be in that lot. 'Oh,' said Lord Kitchener, 'You cur! You must go to war! But my father says, 'You cheeky man, not on your life! That was the end of it!'"

He sits in a huddle at the window, going into a long and extraordinary tale of a feudal, fish-based relationship with the Baillieus that they were probably blissfully unaware of. Meanwhile his bright gimlet eyes take in our docking at Sorrento, where the Von Tilborgs get off happily, holding hands. The rest of us watch them receding down the old wooden pier as the sun comes out abruptly. We look at the Norfolk pines, the Sorrento Hotel. They are great old beach queens, these buildings at every port, mellow from a hundred summers. We take off fast, trying Queenscliff once more, and a second possible landing of Eric Richards.

AT QUEENSCLIFF a parcel of diminutive school kids wait on the open pier. A teacher is herding them. They wave their arms and shout shrilly, as Jodie Jones and William Wallace grab an elbow each of Eric Richards and lever him down the stairs. But there is a definite south-easterly swell, as before. The tide shifts sideways suddenly, smashing The Spirit against the quay. As we watch the children fall wildly, the teacher makes frantic lunges for arms and legs, and the boat pulls swiftly away.

Eric Richards is returned back upstairs, settled down in his corner with sandwiches and tea and apparent equanimity. The schoolkids, upright once more, wave with undiminished enthusiasm. Seagulls whirl around the beach.

We turn back to Melbourne, on the last leg of the trip. Since Sorrento there are more young couples with kids aboard, vigorously scouring the boat. They look up-market. I join instead the discreet trio, which has now finished its lunch. Graeme Latimer of the gold chain writes letters to 'The Age'. It gives him a buzz. He is a stirrer, he says, while June Figg and Clyde Marsden listen deferentially. I ask if they have enjoyed their trip. "Yes, yes indeed," says Graeme Latimer, "in spite of the weather being against us." He sits sedately, refining his next words.

"I feel this vessel fills a definite need, and it deserves good use from Melbourne residents." I, too, remembers the old ferries. In 1940 he took the Weeroona on the Bryant & May Match Picnic, to which he was invited by a secretary friend.

In 1985 there are no squeeze boxes, no singing, no wild excitement at being swung out into the bay. We take our pleasures quietly, but they are pleasures nevertheless. We are speeding back fast

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Nurturing football's endangered species

THE truth is that I am not renowned for my warm devotion to football. Yet I am terribly worried about football coaches. I think they are an endangered species.

Unless we are careful they will go on the endangered species list like the koala, the hump-backed whale and the poor, unfortunate Northern Territory crocodile.

Melburnians are unforgiving. If a football team does not win a premiership it is not the fault of the players, or the committee; it is the sheer incompetence of the coach.

Now, by my estimate, 70 Victorian Football League coaches have been sacked, shot, run out of town or recycled since 1973. The average life expectancy of a coach is 18 months.

Now this past end-of-season something curious has happened. Much recycling has gone on. Tom Hafey has gone from Geelong to the Sydney Swans; John Northey, who was sacked after one year at the Swans, has gone to Melbourne; David Parkin, who was coach at Carlton, has gone to Fitzroy; Robert Walls, who was coach at Fitzroy, has gone to Carlton. In addition, Tony Jewell has returned to Richmond after a spell at St Kilda and on the press bench.

Dr Edelman apparently has purchased Hafey for something over \$100,000 a year. Indeed Dr Edelman, in the classic American tradition, is in the process of buying an entire football team; gentlemen such as Gerard Healy from Melbourne and Maurice Rioli from Richmond have been offered managing director prices.

I understand that in his takeover bid for Melbourne football the Sydney doctor is spending slightly more than Holmes a Court in his offer for BHP.

But what worries me is this. Australian football has always thrived on loathing. There is a naive belief that the game sprang to popularity because the citizens adored the sight of footballers flying to catch the oval pigskin object with Nureyev-like leaps.

Melbourne, a century ago, was composed of tightly knit working-class suburbs. According to one thesis on the Collingwood Football Club, 70 per cent of club memberships at the turn of the century belonged to locals; 80 per cent of members were working laborers, workers in the boot factories.

It was marvellous. The people from Carlton would loathe the people from Fitzroy. The people from Collingwood would loathe the people from Richmond, and almost everybody loathed North Melbourne.



Jack Dyer has written of the awesome battles against North Melbourne, whom they called "shinboners". He says savage shinboners used to get loads of gravel and rocks and dump them in the players' race as ammunition, just in case their team lost.

In his book 'Captain Blood', Jack Dyer ran on at length about his hatred of Collingwood. "It isn't a friendly dislike," said he. "As a club they rankle me. You couldn't like them, they think they are God's gift to football, they shun all outsiders and the only time I like to think of Collingwood is when they lose, because it hurts them so much. I wouldn't drink anything they offered, you wouldn't know what they had done to it."

And of course Lou Richards has written what it was like to be born

in Collingwood and reared in a Maggie's nest. "Ambition to play for Collingwood pounded in the heart of every Collingwood kid."

And of course the Collingwood club was so like a sacred shrine you practically had to cross yourself every time you passed the door.

But it is very difficult to maintain your loathing when players and coaches every season circulate from club to club.

Take Tom Hafey as an example. He played 66 games for Richmond between 1953 and 1958. He coached Richmond from 1966 to 1976. In 1976 he went to Collingwood. You can imagine how that affected little kids all around the depths of Bridge Road and Swan Street. There was nothing more loathsome this side of Beirut than Collingwood. Their patron saint, Jack Dyer, had told them so.

Just conceive that it is possible that they learned to forgive. I don't think it is likely, but imagine the absurd: some of those devoted Richmond kids followed Hafey to dreaded Collingwood.

Lo, in 1982 he is sacked from Collingwood and in 1983 he starts as the new coach at Geelong. The little kids who followed him from Richmond to Collingwood are now expected to enthuse over him at Geelong, a town so far off they've never even been there.

These kids, now turned into schizophrenics, are taking drugs to forget. They are wandering dazed and unknowing up Bridge Road.

But the story is not over. Ye gods, he is not even coach of Geelong any more. He turns up in Sydney, beaming beside Dr Edelman. Already he is wearing a Sydney Swans guernsey. It's like the Pope turning up in a Baptist smock.

And what of the little kids who were so passionate, so devoted back in 1966. They've gone, disillusioned, lost to the game. They are like old comrades who once believed in Stalin. Their faith has been wrenched away.

I am explaining all this because I am associated with an organisation called the Anti Football League and I am terrified that it will take only one more Dr Edelman for us to have nothing to be anti for.

I would suggest respectfully that the Victorian Football League introduce at once some vital laws. Club players no longer will be allowed to switch sides. And the Department of Conservation should put League coaches on the Endangered Species List.

I would suggest that the shooting season be one day late in September, and only one coach be cull every year.

— Keith Dunstan

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